

Statistics

If we take the position after 10...a6 White has scored 54% in just over 200 games. Exactly what he is expected to score. This means the variation is no worse or no better than any other. There are relatively few games as the line has no history.

Illustrative Games

Game 39

□ Hohler ■ Gallagher

Bern 1994

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nf3 Bg7 4 g3 0-0 5 Bg2 d6 6 0-0 Nbd7 7 Nc3 e5
8 e4 exd4 9 Nxd4 Re8 10 h3 a6 11 Re1 Rb8 12 Be3

White has various ways to deploy his pieces on moves 11 and 12. Basically, Black follows the same plan against them all but must be more careful against 12 Rb1 (see Game 41).

12...c5 (Diagram 3)

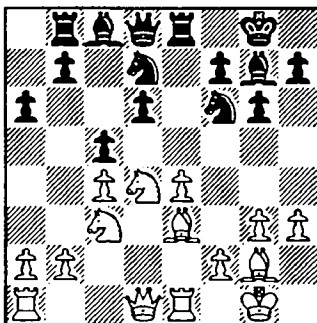


Diagram 3

A radical thrust for the initiative

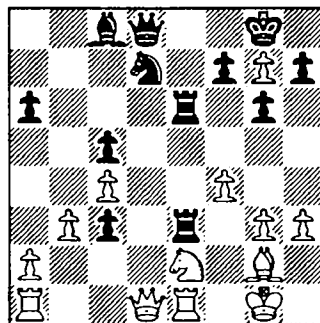


Diagram 4

Now Black has the central pressure

This is the move that shocks the positional men. Not only does Black give himself a backward d-pawn on an open file but he also cedes control of d5.



NOTE: Modern chess players are not so worried about such static details. They are more interested in the dynamics of the position. Black wants to grab the initiative and if that means sacrificing material or making positional concessions – so be it.

13 Nde2 Ne5

This is more promising than the immediate 13...b5.

14 b3 b5 15 f4 Ned7

Black must retreat here as 15...Nc6 is strongly met by 16 e5!.

Black now has the same position as if he had played 13...b5 at once but White has been given two extra moves for free! The claim is that these moves actually harm the white position. The move b3 weakens White on the long dark diagonal while the move f4 means that the bishop on e3 is no longer protected.

16 Qxd6 b4

The reason that Black can get away with such opening play is that he is not really attacking on the queenside at all – White's central play would crush an attack there – but is attacking in the centre himself. The queenside demonstration is just the means employed to destabilise White's e4-point. It can no longer be held.

17 e5!

After 17 Na4 Nxe4 18 Bxe4 Rxe4 both the rook on a1 and the bishop on e3 are hanging. Now you should have a clearer understanding of why Black encouraged the moves b3 and f4.

17...bxc3 18 exf6?

A serious mistake. White should have played 18 Nxc3! Nh5 19 g4 Bf8 20 Qd2 Ng7 when he has a couple of pawns and a strong grip in the centre for the piece. The position can be considered unclear.

18...Rxe3 19 fxg7 Rb6! 20 Qd1 Rbe6 (Diagram 4)

The fine rook manoeuvre has left White stuck in an awkward pin.

21 Rc1 Qf6 22 Qc2 Qe7 23 Kf2 Nf6 24 Rcd1 Bb7 25 Bd5 Bxd5 26 cxd5 R6e4 27 Rd3 c4!

Opening the a7-g1 diagonal so that the queen can get at the king.

28 Rxe3 Rxe3 29 d6 Qa7 30 Qc1?

White had to try 30 bxc4 though after 30...Ne4+ 31 Kg2 both 31...Nxd6 and 31...Qa8 win comfortably for Black.

30...Ne4+ 31 Kg2 Rxg3+! White resigns

In view of 32 Nxc3 Qf2+ 33 Kh1 Nxc3 mate.

Game 40

□ Whiteley ■ Gallagher

Royan 1989

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nf3 Bg7 4 g3 0-0 5 Bg2 d6 6 0-0 Nbd7 7 Nc3 e5 8 e4 exd4 9 Nxd4 Re8 10 h3 a6 11 Re1 Rb8 12 b3

A typical prophylactic move from White in this variation. He defends c4 before Black can attack it. There is no longer much point to ...Ne5 so Black gets on with the attack at once.

12...c5 13 Nc2

The knight retreats here, rather than e2, to defend the rook on a1 (important in certain variations), and so as not to interfere with the rook on e1's protection of e4.

13...b5! 14 cxb5

Black would continue in the same way after 14 Qxd6.

14...axb5 15 Qxd6 Rb6!

The white e-pawn has sufficient protection for the moment so Black brings up the heavy artillery to bombard it. Note that this time he delayed ...b5-b4 for a move as after 15...b4 16 Na4 the queen's rook can no longer be transported to the centre.

16 Qd1 b4 17 Na4 Rbe6 18 Bb2 Qe7

White had defended his e-pawn by tactical means: 18...Nxe4? 19 Bxg7 Kxg7 20 Bxe4 Rxe4 21 Rxe4 Rxe4 22 Nxc5! is favourable for White.

19 Ne3 Bb7 20 f3

You may wonder why Black has been piling up on the e-pawn if all White needs to do is to play this simple pawn move to defend it. The whole point is, though, that Black has been trying to force this little pawn move as it seriously weakens the white kingside. Black will now switch his attack to the dark squares in this sector of the board. It may have been better for White to return the pawn with 20 e5.

20...Nh5! 21 Bxg7 Kxg7 22 g4 Nf4 23 Qd2 Ne5 (Diagram 5)

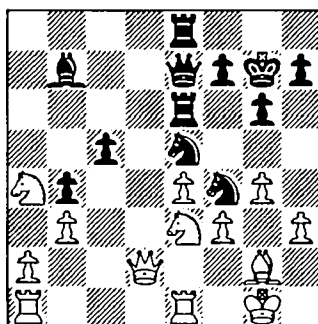


Diagram 5

What wonderful knights!

Black now threatens 24...Nxh3+ 25 Bxh3 Nxf3+ so there is no time for White to prevent Black taking control of the d-file. Rather than dying quietly White initiated complications with 25 Nf5+ but these quickly turned sour. Here are the remaining moves.

24 Rf1 Rd8 25 Nf5+ gxf5 26 Qxf4 Nd3 27 Qe3 f4!? 28 Qd2 c4! 29 bxc4 Qd7 30 a3 Qxa4 31 axb4 Qd7 32 Qc3+ Qd4+ 33 Qxd4+ Rxd4 34 Rfd1 Rd6 35 Ra7 Rd7 36 Kf1 Rxc4! 37 Rxb7 Rxb7 38 Rxd3 Rxc4 39 Rd2 Rb1+ 40 Kf2 R7b2 41 Rxb2 Rxb2+ 42 Kg1 Kf6 43 h4 Ke5 44 g5 h6 45 h5 hxc5 46 Bh3 Kd4 47 Bg4 Ke3 48 Kf1 Rh2 49 Kg1 Rh4 50 Kf1 f6 51 Kg2 Ke2 52 Kg1 Rxc4+ White resigns

Game 41

□ Schwartzman ■ Nisipeanu

Bucharest 1994

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nf3 Bg7 4 g3 0-0 5 Bg2 d6 6 0-0 Nbd7 7 Nc3 e5
8 e4 exd4 9 Nxd4 Re8 10 h3 a6 11 Re1

For a while it became fashionable for White to withdraw his knight from d4 before it was hit with ...c7-c5. The moves 11 Nb3 and 11 Nde2 are usually described as prophylactic but I prefer to call them cowardly. White is just trying to avoid complications at all costs. The knight was, after all, perfectly well placed in the middle and could only be dislodged by Black taking positional risks. Not surprisingly, Black is able to find adequate counterplay by 'normal' means.

1) 11 Nb3 Ne5 12 c5 (12 Qe2 Be6!) 12...dxc5 13 Nxc5 Qe7 14 Nb3 Be6 15 Qc2 Rad8, Spassov-Van Wely, Munich 1992. Black's active pieces more than compensate for White's central pawn majority.

2) 11 Nde2 Nb6 (11...Rb8!?) 12 b3 Nxe4! 13 Nxe4 Rxe4! 14 Bxe4 Bxa1 15 Bg2 Bf6 16 Nf4 Rb8 17 Be3 Bd7 18 Bxb6 cxb6 19 Qxd6 Bc6 20 Qxd8 Rfxd8 21 Nd5 Draw agreed Nikolic-Gelfand, Wijk aan Zee 1992.

11...Rb8 12 Rb1! (Diagram 6)

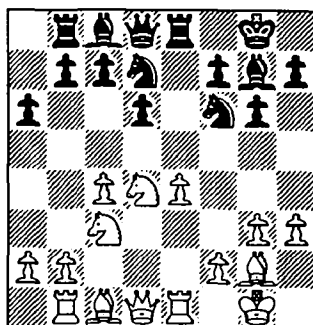


Diagram 6

Preparing for Black's queenside action

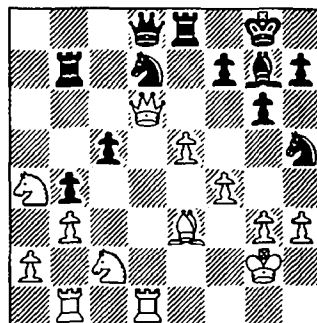


Diagram 7

White's position is overwhelming

This innocuous-looking move has caused Black quite a few problems. I think White players found this move by a process of elimination. It doesn't do a lot but on the other hand it doesn't do any harm either. It doesn't interfere with the defence of the e-pawn (12 Be3), it doesn't expose White on the long diagonal (12 b3) and it doesn't deny White the chance for Qxd6 (in certain games White played an early Qc2).

Not only did White players try and make the ...c7-c5 and ...b7-b5 advance less appetising (12 Rb1) but some of them decided to prevent it altogether. The most obvious way to do this is 12 a4. At first White players were reluctant to play such an anti-positional move. The point

is that if Black meets 12 a4 with 12...a5 (12...Nc5 and 12...Ne5 are also possibilities with ...a5 sometimes coming later) he obtains outposts for his pieces on c5 and b4. However, just as Black can get away with his anti-positional advance ...c7-c5, White, too, can get away with a2-a4 because of the time Black has spent on the now useless moves 10...a6 and 11...Rb8.

12...Ne5 13 b3 c5 14 Nc2 b5?

A mistake. The queenside advance simply doesn't work in this position. Black's attempts to rehabilitate the variation have centred around 14...Be6 or 14...Nc6. Originally I had assumed that if Black couldn't play ...b7-b5 his position would be bad, but this doesn't seem to be the case. For example, Yin Hao-Ye Jiangchuan, Shanghai 2000 went 14...Nc6 15 a4 Be6 16 Bb2 h5 17 Qd2 Nh7! 18 Rd1 Be5! 19 f4 Bg7 20 Kh1 Qa5 with an unclear game.

15 cxb5 axb5 16 f4 Ned7 17 Qxd6 b4

There is no good way for Black to continue. 17...Nh5 18 Qd3! c4 19 Qe3 is also good for White.

18 Na4 Bb7 19 e5 Nh5 20 Rd1 Bxg2 21 Kxg2 Rb7 22 Be3 (Diagram 7)

Black is a pawn down with a terrible position. His attempts to confuse the issue are, not surprisingly, easily dealt with.

22...g5 23 Qd5 gxf4 24 gxf4 Qc8 25 Qf3 Nxe5 26 Qxh5 Qc6+ 27 Kf2 Qe4 28 Qe2 Rbe7 29 Nxc5 Qf5 30 Rg1 Ng6 31 Qd3 Qxh3 32 Rh1 Qc8 33 Rh5 Qg4 34 Qf5 Black resigns

Black resigned as he can't keep the queens on.

The Classical 6...Nbd7: Other Systems

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nf3 Bg7 4 g3 0-0 5 Bg2 d6 6 0-0 Nbd7 7 Nc3 e5 8 e4 (Diagram 8)

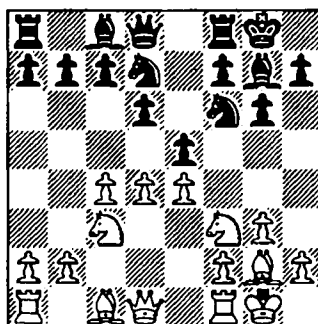


Diagram 8
A balanced position